



Anyone who stops learning is old, whether at twenty or eighty.

—Henry Ford

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The easier way is to be part of a like-minded group, work on something together, and then present it to the government.

What if an organisation cannot afford to be a member of an association? What would help then?

It is all about relationship building. The government bodies operate around their structure and codes of conduct. Once you get into relationship building with the government, there will come a time when your voice will be heard. It might take some time, but you would have to prove your worth to the government in terms of what you can do and help the government achieve.

Even for an individual, if there is a strong business case, you will be heard. I, in my tenure with the government, have found that the government does take cognizance of the issues raised by an individual, provided the issues are genuine. It is not difficult for an individual to contribute to a policy. However, never go to the government with a problem, but with a solution as well.

What is the best way for an individual to get heard, as different ministries must be receiving an infinite number of emails?

If you have good intent, you will never miss out is something I always say. Advocacy is with everyone. If the objective is good and the intent is strong enough, it will always get heard. Writing to ask is an art that you should master before reaching out to the government.

Your proposal should be backed by solid research. If you tick all the boxes, then it would not matter whether you are an association or an individual; all that would matter is your research and intent. If you have researched well, and you know exactly what you are presenting, and the kind of impact it can make, there is no way you will go unheard.

Is there a stage where the government extends its arm and consults associations and individuals?

Consulting is done at almost all the stages of policy making. A policy never comes from the dream of a government officer. It is only from the industry that they get some hint, or some trigger. The first draft is prepared after rigorous consultation with the industry. The consultative process happens at the beginning, it happens at the mid-level, and also at the last stages of policy drafting.

The key word here is engage, and one has to engage with the government. Government does not run a “May I help you?” kind of a counter where you go and tell them about your research about a particular matter. There are several events hosted by the government where you can engage in a conversation with it. My two cents for individuals and associations include constant engagement with the government and developing a habit of co-creating with the same. All the policies have a tangible as well as a non-tangible aspect.

What do you mean by relationship building?

One should always be in a consultative process with the government. Though companies cannot reveal everything about them to the government within the first meeting. There are a lot of portals now being used by the government to invite feedback. One should always keep an eye on these portals as the policies are uploaded on these for consultation. Relationship building, as per my understanding, is more of participation. It is not a government policy; it is your policy.

Some of the portals I remember are InvestIndia, PIB, and MyGov. One can also log into the websites of different ministries. However, there is no one-stop shop for getting what you need. What you need to do is a combination of hard and smart work. **EFY**